

The big difference here comes down to what we mean by Linux. People use the term “Linux” to mean many different things. At the most basic level, Linux means the Linux kernel. A kernel is the core of any operating system. But the confusion stems from the fact that most people also refer to Linux distributions as simply “Linux.” However, Linux distributions aren’t just the Linux kernel. They contain many other pieces of software, and although it is exactly the same kernel that runs under all the different distros that you find today, the software they build over it is what gives the distro its own identity.

Going by that definition, Android, and indeed, ChromeOS, fit perfectly well into the definition of a Linux distribution, that are admittedly niche in their reach and purpose, but are still Linux distributions nonetheless. Because Linux is open-source, Google’s Android developers could modify the Linux kernel to fit their needs. Linux gives Android developers a pre-built, already maintained operating system kernel to start with so they don’t have to write their own kernel. This is the way many different devices are built – for example, the PlayStation 4 uses the open-source FreeBSD kernel, while the Xbox One uses the Windows NT kernel found in modern versions of Windows. Google is a big fan of the Linux way of doing things and this reflects in the internal workings of the company. ‘Goobuntu’ is an internal Linux distribution that they have built on top of, you guessed it, Ubuntu.

A major accusation labelled against any corporation that backs an open source project is that they serve themselves above everything else. True as that may be, we do not see how it is a negative. Google, has basically added the parts that were needed to have the kernel run on mobile devices. Years before this, other vendors were facing great difficulty in making Linux run efficiently on mobile devices, even laptops. Anybody looking for a way now would find a great guide in the way that code is implemented in the Android Open Source Project.

As informed consumers, we need to understand that corporations do not have a heart or a soul, but they do have a balance sheet to maintain. If their purpose is solved by taking a public project forward, or even tangentially into a direction it has not gone before, we should be happy for it, because that paves the way for any that follow them to have a ready blueprint to see how that very particular problem is to be solved. Issac Newton once claimed that the reason he was able to see far ahead in science is because he stood on the shoulders of giants. This is how mankind has always progressed through the ages – gradual development, one on top of the other, until eventually, something great is made.